

RANDOM REFLECTIONS

(Translation of **Vichar-Pothi**)

VINOBA

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Preface

Acharya Vinoba Bhave (1895-1982) is undoubtedly one of the greatest personalities of the last century. Acclaimed as 'Gandhi's spiritual successor' he was, in fact, a successor to most of the ancient spiritual traditions of the world. Philosophy, metaphysics, sociology, political science, pedagogy, economics—there was hardly any subject that his genius did not touch and in which he did not contribute novel, original and insightful ideas. Those ideas assume more importance in the light of the fact that Vinoba was not only a theoretician, but he also practised what he preached, and demonstrated the practicality of what he conceived. The Bhoodan-Yajna, which he initiated and led, gave more than 2.5 million acres of land to the poor agricultural labourers. This has no parallel in the history of the world.

Vinoba's books, most of which are compilations on different subjects culled from his speeches and writings, have been, and are being, published in various Indian languages. However, only a few of them have been published in English. Hence most of his writings have remained inaccessible in English. This is a serious deficiency, when English is the most widely known international language and the perplexed world urgently needs to become aware of Vinoba's experiential wisdom.

This is what prompted me to resolve to prepare a few books in English by editing and translating Vinoba's thoughts on different subjects, which have not been covered in Vinoba's available literature in English, despite being fully aware of my incompetence to do the job, simply because it has not yet been attempted. The attempt is to give a broad outline of some of Vinoba's thoughts with the hope that they would motivate the readers to delve into Vinoba's timeless wisdom.

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Publisher's Note

Vinoba's sagacious words are a treasure-house for humankind. They were perhaps ahead of the times wherein they were uttered, but they are certainly relevant now, when the forces of what Gandhiji called 'a satanic civilisation' are seeking to overpower human spirit. These words can reassure humankind about the ultimate triumph of truth and inspire and guide it in the fight against those forces.

However, only a few of Vinoba's works had been translated in English, whose outreach is increasing in the present era. It is gratifying that Dr. Parag Cholkar has now edited and translated Vinoba's thoughts on some subjects, which have hitherto been unavailable in English, and presented them in the form of nine books. We are happy in publishing them in printed form, while Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan is publishing them as e-books.

We are thankful to Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti (Nagpur) and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha for their financial assistance for this project.

‘Vichar-Pothi’ is a collection of stray thoughts, which Vinoba noted down for some time, between 1928 and 1931. Its style is unique. It has no particular form. The thoughts are not of the same type; some appear ordinary, while the depth in some is unfathomable. They are not logically or systematically arranged, neither subject-wise nor in any other way. Yet they show Vinoba’s keen observation, deep scholarship, mastery over words, and even a sense of humour. They are backed by prolonged reflection and experimentation. Naturally, there is no vagueness or tentativeness in them. They demonstrate that Vinoba’s philosophy of life had been formed at that time. ‘Vichar-Pothi’ presents it in a succinct style.

When the book was first published (in Marathi), it had 736 thoughts. Later, Vinoba omitted 36. Editions in Indian languages have been published thereafter with 700 thoughts. However, there are only 594 thoughts in this English translation. The reasons are many. Some thoughts, as Vinoba himself has stated, are intelligible to their author alone. Some thoughts have references to stories and characters from Indian mythology; and although they are fairly intelligible to Indian readers, the English edition would require long footnotes. Some reflections are simply untranslatable. Had Vinoba been around, he could have been consulted about the meanings of some unintelligible and esoteric thoughts. But that is not possible now. Readers will have, therefore, to be satisfied with what could be presented here, at least for the time being.

‘Vichar-Pothi’, in fact, needs an elaborate commentary to unravel mysterious import and unfold hidden significance in many reflections. Aphorisms, as is well accepted, do need commentaries.

‘Vichar-Pothi’ was first translated by Vasant Nargolkar, a veteran sarvodaya worker, who had written a few books on Vinoba’s thoughts, and had the benefit of

having contact with him. The translation, titled ‘Random Reflections’ was published in 1971. However, it has been out of print for many years. I have thoroughly revised the book before preparing this second edition. Although I have tried to retain as much matter from the original translation as I thought fit, responsibility of what appears here, as well as for errors and deficiencies, of course, remains entirely mine.

I am happy that Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan has taken initiative for the publication of this book as an e-book, while Paramdham Prakashan is publishing it in printed form. Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha have provided financial assistance to this project. I am grateful to them. I also take this opportunity to thank my friend Kishor Deshpande for the pains he has taken in going through the manuscript and giving valuable suggestions. Readers are welcome to point out errors and deficiencies and suggest modifications.

— Parag Cholkar

Introduction

The set-up of my life has been experimentation through meditation and meditation through experimentation. This is what I call *nididhyasa* (constant contemplation). It gives rise to thoughts and ideas. Normally, I am not inclined to record them. But once in a certain state of my mind, I felt inclined to do so. Not that I started noting down all the thoughts; I wrote down only a few. It is of those that this short volume is made. Fortunately, that tendency did not last long. It subsided within a few days.

There was no idea of publishing this collection of thoughts. That is why it remained just a sheaf of loose papers. Moreover, most of the thoughts were expressed in such a style that they were intelligible to their author alone. Yet the curious started making copies of the manuscript. About a hundred and fifty such copies were probably made during the last twelve years. But as bad spelling and illegible handwriting have of late become widely prevalent, and also because not every copy was made from the original, many wrong readings crept into those copies. Consequently, a few sayings became meaningless. Hence, at last, this printed edition had to be taken out.

These reflections are not like well-known maxims. A maxim has to have form. These are almost formless. Nor are they like aphorisms. Aphorisms require a logical construction. These have been expressed freely. What should then these be called? I call them just 'mutterings'. These thoughts, undoubtedly, have the support of ancient scriptures, but they are also independent in their own way. If I may use the words of Jnanadeva, this may be described as an attempt to repay the debt of the linguistic heritage of our predecessors.

— Vinoba

21-1-1942

Random Reflections

1. Spiritual conduct means natural conduct; that is, pure conduct.
2. The essence of Hindu dharma¹:
 - (i) Tolerance towards different kinds of religious practices.
 - (ii) Freedom of thought;
 - (iii) Firm insistence on ethical principles.
3. Service to those who come to you unsought, to saints, to those who are suffering and to those who hate you is the best kind of service.
4. There is no inherent strength in untruth. Even for its existence, it has necessarily to take the support of truth.
5. Truth, self-restraint and service are the three essential points in spiritual life.
6. Individual self—impure, imperfect.
Self—pure, imperfect.
God—pure, perfect.
7. God, preceptor, Self, dharma and saints are the five objects, which deserve to be revered and worshipped.
8. Why is Hindu dharma dear to me?
 - (i) Innumerable saintly personages—such as Vamadeva, Buddhadeva, Jnanadeva etc.

1. Dharma is normally translated as 'religion', but is a much wider concept. It is that which holds and supports everything. Its meanings include right conduct and duties incumbent upon one because of one's nature and position.

Hindu dharma is not really a religion, in the sense that it is not a closely-knit concrete system of beliefs like other religions and, therefore, the term 'Hindu dharma' has been used instead of 'Hinduism'.

(ii) Many social institutions and individual disciplines; arrangements for the cultivation of mind and practices—such as *yajna*², the institution of *ashrams*³, cow protection etc.

(iii) Eternal moral principles—such as nonviolence, truth etc.

(iv) Subtle and profound metaphysical thoughts—such as the postulate that God is immanent in every living being.

(v) Scientific method of self-control—such as the science of yoga.

(vi) The belief that life and religion make one integral whole; the path of selfless and desireless action.

(vii) Literature based on direct spiritual revelation—such as the Gita and the Upanishads.

9. God is neither good nor evil. Or He is both good and evil. Or, again, He is unadulterated good.

10. How can one judge one's progress in achieving control over the palate?

(i) Examination, purification and refinement of the sense of test.

(ii) Examination and improvement in physical well-being.

2. The term '*yajna*' was originally used for the Vedic rite involving offering to the sacrificial fire. It is now a synonym of sacrifice.

3. Hindu tradition divides life in four stages of twenty five years each: *Brahmacharya* (when one is supposed to remain celibate and concentrate on studies), *Garhasthya* (when one is supposed to carry out the duties of a householder and discharge family responsibilities), *Vanaprastha* (when one is supposed to retire from the family responsibilities and become a hermit) and *Sannyasa* (when one should completely renounce worldly life and become a wandering ascetic).

(iii) Examination of mental disorders and passions like desire and anger and purging the mind of them.

(iv) Removal of (spiritual) ignorance.

11. Meditation can be of six kinds:

(i) Introspection and analysis of one's self.

(ii) Contemplation of the nature of God.

(iii) Constant study of the four *mahavakyas*.⁴

(iv) Contemplation and repetition of God's Name.

(v) Understanding the Divine play in the universe.

(vi) Observation of saintly lives.

12. Pride of power, pride of wealth, pride of physical might, pride of physical beauty, pride of family, pride of learning, pride of experience, pride of achievements and pride of good character—these are the nine types of pride. But none of them is as dangerous as the impression that 'I am free from pride.'

13. I have become a prey to passions. O Lord! Fulfil my desires or make me desireless or concentrate my desire on the Self (to the exclusion of other objects). If You fulfil my desires, I will offer my life at Your feet. If You make me desireless, I will offer my intellect. If You concentrate my desire on the Self, I shall make an offering of the desire itself.

14. O Mother! no one else has given me what you gave me. But even you, while living, did not give me what you are giving me after your death. This much evidence of the immortality of the soul is enough to me.

15. History means the course of all life from time immemorial up to now. Mythology means the abiding part of experience that has survived throughout this time.

4. Literally, great sayings. There are four such sayings in the Upanishads, which encapsulate the essence of spirituality. Refer 98.

16. Experience is beyond reasoning. Faith is sustained by experience, but it is beyond it.

17. Where do I wish to reside?

First reply, 'Anywhere'.

Second reply, 'In the company of the wise'.

Third reply, 'In the Self'.

18. Vedas are like a forest and the Upanishad are like cows (who graze in that forest). The Gita is like milk (of those cows). Saints are drinking that milk. I am hopeful of getting the leftover.

19. Socrates said, "All sin is just ignorance." On the other hand, it can also be said that "Ignorance too is sin". When the Gita calls ignorance a demoniacal tendency⁵ (16.3), this is what she means. The saying of Socrates tells us how to look at the sins committed by others. The Gita tells us how to look at our own ignorance.

20. Ignorance about the Self is the fundamental ignorance. Not to be aware of this ignorance amounts to 'ignorance of the ignorance'; or, in the language of mathematics, (ignorance)². To deny that one is in the category of persons who are ignorant of the ignorance is (ignorance)³. This is what is called erudition.

21. The prattle of a child becomes him, because there is a loving and indulgent mother. The ignorance of man becomes him, because of forgiving God.

22. If one cares for one's possessions, that amounts to the insult of indwelling Self. If one does not care for one's possessions, that amounts to the insult of the Universal Self. Hence non-possession is the safer way.

23 How can it be said that I reared a child who survived. What about other children? Can it be said that God killed them? I should accept the responsibility of both, survival of one and death of others, or attribute both to Him. The saints adopted the latter course. To adopt the first

requires great courage.

24. "It is God Himself who creates in us the inclination towards either sin or virtue, what can we do about it?"

"Yes, it is true. And it is He Himself who enjoys or suffers the good or bad consequences thereof. What can you do about it also?"

25. To achieve something is better than lack of any achievement. But to shed the consciousness of being the doer is still better.

26. To worship God as husband is known as '*madhura*' devotion. '*Madhura*' devotion is nothing but *brahmacharya*.⁵ For, if the person adopting it is a man, he will have to get rid of his consciousness of being a male. If the person is a woman, she cannot look upon anyone except God as her husband.

Shukadeva⁶ illustrates the first type, while the *gopis*⁷, the second.

27. The function of a preceptor is only to undersign and testify to the disciple's knowledge; for the rest, the disciple has to be self-reliant.

28. Service divided by egoism = Devotion.⁸

5. In a narrow sense, celibacy. In a broader sense, a course of conduct adopted for the realisation of Brahman, the Supreme reality.

6. The sage Shuka is known to be so passionless that women did not feel that he was a male.

7. The milkmaids in Gokul where Lord Krishna resided in His childhood.

8. Less the ego, more would be the value of devotion and more the ego, less would be the value of devotion for the same amount of service.

29. My mother used to say, "The injunction that while giving charity, discretion in regard to the right person, right time and right place should be used is a humbug. It is sufficient to have compassion."

I used to argue, "But charity towards the undeserving harms the donee also."

To this her usual retort was, "Who are we to decide who is deserving and who is not? The needy person at our door is God Himself."

30. Restraint in conduct is desirable, for mind then remains free.

31. In the Gita, the Himalaya Mountain has been cited as the Divine manifestation of steadfastness (10.25). One whose reason is steadfast is virtually in the Himalayas.

32. Those who valued jewels in terms of millions of rupees have missed their pricelessness. The saints are the real connoisseurs of jewels. For, they look upon the jewels as valueless.

33. Destruction of the body is no destruction at all. Destruction of Self is an impossibility. Destruction or ruination therefore, means loss of discriminating reason.

34. What is the best use of music and drawing? Music should sing God's Name and drawing should sketch God's form.

35. Though name and form are illusions, God's Name and form should not be called so.

36. What do ethics encompass? The real question, in fact, is 'What is not included in ethics?' "That one should be awake and on guard even during sleep" is the last word in morality.

37. The lotus symbolizes detached sacredness.

38. A devotee is always humble. He is satisfied with the sight of the 'feet' of the Lord.⁹

39. The last great sleep (death) is as necessary and blissful to one who has worked hard throughout one's life, as is sleep every night to one who works for the whole day. Death is the mildest form of God.

40. In Sanskrit, the root 'हन्' ('han') means 'to kill' and also 'to multiply'. Violence multiplies sin.

41. The evening prayer is verily the remembrance of God at the last hour.

42. When I compare the intensity of my feeling with the intensity of the feeling of saints like Tukaram, I find that mine is quite insignificant. But what can 'I' do about it?

43. There is no true joy without Self-realization. The mother rejoices at the sight of her child, for she sees her own Self in it.

44. Distortions of the most sublime ideas are extremely noxious. There is no other nourishing food like fresh fruit, but there is also no other unwholesome food like rotten fruit.

45. A piece of stone becomes smooth and round by the flowing water of river, but it does not get soaked. Company of the wise and the virtuous will make our conduct moral, but that is not sufficient. We should get soaked in the loving devotion to God.

46. Selfishness is evidently naked. What is important is to guard ourselves from altruism.¹⁰

9. There are quotation marks around the word 'feet' in original, which seems to suggest that Vinoba is perhaps referring to the foundation of divinity.

10. Vinoba appears to say that one should not have vanity of doing good to others.

47. The message of the Bhagavad-Gita is non-attachment; and yet she exhorts us to be attached to God.

48. Swadeshi¹¹ is the science about compassionate service to all creatures. It does not mean narrow-minded attachment to 'me and mine'.

49. Where there appears lack of coordination between reason and emotion, there is lack of control of the sense organs.

50. The highest type of devotion to God is equanimity and even-mindedness, which means Self-knowledge, which means passionlessness.

51. There is humility in worshipping the Lord with form and attributes. Worship of attributeless and formless God involves responsibility of attaining the Self; and consequently, there are more travails.

52. The injunction that one should give in charity only to the deserving and only at the proper place and proper time holds good even while dealing with oneself.

53. Knowledge cannot arise from ignorance.

54. There cannot be any 'martyrdom' of the weak. It is a privilege of the strong.

55. *Rajas* says, if I perform any act, I will enjoy its fruit. *Tamas* says, if the fruit is to be renounced, I will not work at all. Both, in essence, are one and the same.¹²

11. Swadeshi literally means that which belongs to one's own country. However, it has been defined by Gandhiji as 'that spirit in us which restricts us to the use and service of our immediate surroundings to the exclusion of the more remote.'

12. Indian tradition specifies three *gunas* as basic qualities. They are : *Sattva* (goodness, harmony), *rajas* (passion, restlessness) and *tamas* (ignorance and inertia).

56. 'From whom the people do not shrink and who does not shrink from them'.¹³ People need service and a devotee makes himself available. A devotee needs an object for service, and he gets people to serve.

57. A man was unhappy when a dog barked and disturbed his sleep. But when he learnt that the barking made the thieves take to their heels, he was pleased.

58. *Brahmacharya* is a means for attaining the spiritual goal. The institution of *Brahmacharyashram* is a social institution conducive to spiritual development.

59. In Europe, the system of separate nations is being tried; in India, the system of united nationhood.

60. It is impossible to observe to their fullest extent nonviolence, truth and other vows without renouncing the sense of being the doer of our actions.

61. Power, wealth and grandeur are the distinctive attributes of the Lord; a devotee should not aspire for them.

62. Truth cannot be defined; for, any definition itself is based on Truth.

63. There is often no difference in robbing a man of his grains at the point of a revolver and buying it from him with money.

64. To regard a clod of earth, a stone and gold as of equal value is the main principle of true economics.

65. Religion is a bridge that takes us from worldly life to spiritual liberation. That is why its one leg is in worldly affairs and the other is in spiritual liberation.

13. The Lord has said this in the Gita (12.15) while describing the devotee dear to Him.

66. All religions are partial embodiments of Truth.

67. The seed of death is in the desire to continue to live. Once that desire ceases, death dies.

68. "I am Brahman" does not contradict, "Thou art Brahman".¹⁴

69. "I am", "I am That", "I do not exist."

70. Knowledge first, action afterwards and devotion in the end—that has been the sequence of my spiritual journey. A different sequence cannot be ruled out. All the three ways (of God-realization) are, in essence, one.

71. Service at close quarters, respect from a distance, knowledge from within.

72. The river Ganga is at times turbid, at times clear. But it is always holy. The Self, like the Ganga, is always sacred. It is sacred because it flows ceaselessly.

73. Uddhava could not bear separation from Lord Krishna even for a minute when He was alive, but after His death, he could bear separation from Him. Arjuna could bear separation from Krishna when He was alive, but Krishna's death made him restless.

74. The renunciation of the fruit of action is considered superior to meditation. For, there can be subtle selfishness even in meditation.

75. Gross disorders and passions in the mind are like a hard rock, which does not allow the stream of devotion to start flowing. When those gross disorders and passions are conquered, devotion starts flowing. Yet, subtle distortions of the mind remain. The stream flows through

14. The Supreme, the Ultimate Truth, the Supreme Self. Consummation of the evolution of individual self lies in merging with Brahman; that is, attaining spiritual liberation.

brittle rocks; therefore, it makes noise. It signifies agitation in the devotee's mind. When subtle distortions too cease to exist, that agitation subsides. That is the highest stage of devotion.

76. The experience that 'I belong to Him (God)' is devoid of egoism, but it is indirect. The experience that 'I belong to myself' is not indirect, but it is egoistic.

77. The secret of why saints yearn for an opportunity to serve the people would be understood when one learns to see God in every living being.

78. The mother is fond of her child with all its drawbacks. Similarly, a devotee is fond of Brahman with all its appearances, including the phenomenal world.

79. *Swadharma*¹⁵ comes to one naturally. A mother does not learn from scriptures her duty of suckling the child.

80. Everyone is indeed the Self. But rare is the person who possesses the knowledge of Self.

81. I discover many a time that thoughts develop in deep sleep. Seed covered with soil appears to have been lost, but it continues to develop underground. It seems this is a similar process.

82. All the words in the dictionary have only one meaning—'God'.

83. Divine manifestations are worthy of meditation. They may not necessarily be worthy of emulation.

84. There are three types of 'oppositional' devotion.¹⁶

15. Natural duty that accrues because of one's nature, position and situation.

16. A kind among the various kinds of devotion to the Lord. An 'oppositional' devotee is so engrossed in thinking about how to oppose the Lord that he is said to get liberated after death.

- (i) Firm commitment to atheism.
- (ii) Passionate attachment to worldly things.
- (iii) Immoral conduct adopted deliberately, with the conviction that it is worthwhile.

85. One course of action: Elimination of sin through performance of meritorious deeds and elimination of the merit so earned through the development of non-attachment.

Another course of action: Elimination of merit through performance of sinful deeds and elimination of sin through remorse.

The first course is the one adopted by the devotees and the other by the followers of the Shakta cult.¹⁷

86. The skill of (Self-)knowledge lies in eliminating desire and anger by making them fight with each other.

87. Let us be angry with God, with ourselves, with anger itself.

88. When one is in the state of non-duality, examination of others verily becomes self-examination. For, in that state, the marks on the back of a buffalo appear on one's back.¹⁸

89. Thought is galloping ahead, while practice is lagging behind. Until now, there was at least this saving factor that practice was proceeding in the direction of

17. A *tantric* cult which worships the Goddess in various forms. Many of its practices are considered immoral and objectionable by normal moral standards.

18. This refers to an incident in the life of saint Jnanadeva. Once his detractors taunted him whether there was unity between him and a buffalo of the same name. When Jnanadeva replied in the affirmative, they lashed the buffalo. It is said that the marks of the lashes appeared on Jnanadeva's back.

thought. Now there is no such saving factor to rely on. For, thought has advanced so far ahead that it has become indiscernible in which direction it has headed. Under such circumstances, God's mercy alone can save.

90. 'Why is it that the Gita names brahmacharya and nonviolence as bodily penance (17.14)?'¹⁹

Because the Gita wants that the force of lust and wrath should at least not be allowed to cross the boundaries of the body.

91. A painter is unable to assess correctly a picture from near it, though he himself has painted it. He has deliberately to move a little away from it and then have a look at it. It is not possible to resolve the mystery of creation without an attitude of neutrality.

92. It is safe to love the enemy.

93. A devotee possesses the art of taking advantage of any situation that he happens to face.

"If God becomes a kin, all fortunes of their own accord would wait on you." (Tukaram)

94. The Self is like a sealed jar containing the sacred water of river Ganga, while the Supreme Self is like that river. Both are equally capable of washing away sins, but there is difference in their power to remove miseries.

95. Vision of the Self is just a foretaste of ultimate spiritual liberation. Vision of God amounts to a sumptuous feast of spiritual liberation. It is possible to have an experience of the first state even while residing in this mortal body. The second one is possible only after the dissolution of body.

96. Sympathy for someone who is drowning does not mean that one should drown oneself along with him. It means that one should try to save him while saving oneself.

97. The effort to attain mastery over breath can be useful in developing a fearless mind.

98. Four progressively higher stages of *advaita*¹⁹ have been suggested in the four *mahavakyas* (great sayings):

“*Pradyanam Brahma*”—Knowledge is Brahman. This first stage signifies acquisition of the knowledge of non-duality.

“*Ayamatma Brahma*”—This Self itself is Brahman. This second stage signifies God-realization.

“*Aham Bramasmi*”—I am Brahman. This third stage signifies Self-realization.

“*Tat Twam asi*”—You are That, that is, Brahman. This fourth stage signifies the urge to redeem the world.

99. Many communities within the ambit of Hindu dharma are found to have eschewed meat-eating. This can be considered as a special characteristic of that religion. But great care has to be taken to see to it that this characteristic promotes compassion towards all living beings and does not foster an attitude of considering all beings as separate from one another.

100. I win the whole world through non-stealing. I renounce it through non-possession.

101. Saint Ramdas says, “He who commits theft in his own house is a fool.” Every thief commits theft in his own house.²⁰ Therefore, he is indeed a fool.

102. Being violent, a lion has always to look back.²¹ A nonviolent person has no need to look back.

19. The philosophy of non-duality between the individual Self and the Supreme Self, that is, Brahman. Here, reference is to spiritual evolution towards realizing this ultimate unity.

20. For, the whole universe is the home to all humanity.

21. To see whether anyone is about to attack it.

103. Valour and forgiveness define each other.

104. If, and when, acceptance of personal service from another person is good for me, then under those circumstances his service to me must be good for him too; and vice-versa.

105. From my childhood, no other musical instrument has appeared to me as sweet as the flute. The flute is India's national musical instrument. It is available to all from the poor to the rich. At night, at a quiet hour, when one happens to hear from afar the notes of a flute, one is reminded of the divine life of Lord Krishna.

106. One should proceed quietly, yet firmly, on the path of selfless action, like a tortoise.

Like a tortoise, one should bear attacks from the world on one's strong back.

Like a tortoise, one should withdraw one's sense organs from the objects of the senses.

Like a tortoise, one should have loving eyes.

107. Those who are eager to show the people the right path are not fit to do so, and those who are fit to do so are not inclined to do so. Let God find a way out of this perplexing situation!

108. Development of liking even for a particular wholesome diet amounts to violence.

109. His God is lost to him who forgets the principle that ‘God resides in every living being’.

110. Forgetfulness with regard to what must be remembered as a duty is a sign of mental laziness.

111. Religion consists of love for one's own religion, respect for other religions and indifference to irreligion.

112. Lord Rama's feet must have touched innumerable stones in His way from Ayodhya to Lanka. But only Ahalya was redeemed. Likewise, Ahalya in the form of a stone

must have been touched by the feet of innumerable persons, but the touch of Rama's feet alone redeemed her. Let all veritably become stones in the path of the saints. Then those for whom time has become ripe would be redeemed.²²

113. Let the science of education never forget the story of Rama and Ahalya. Then its vanity will wane and its vision will become clear.²³

114. There is a difference between inward peace and complacent satisfaction with little. The first is a spiritual attitude; the second is worldly, which may either be good or bad. If good, it will strengthen the spiritual progress.

115. God is true. Religion is true. The saints are true. For, truth is God, truth is religion, and truth denotes the nature of saints.

116. From untruth to truth, from darkness to light, from death to immortality—this is the *uttarayan*²⁴ of a spiritual seeker.

117. We should take care of our own spiritual endeavour. This endeavour is capable of taking care of the ultimate fruition. In other words, God can take care of that fruition.

118. He alone sees who sees love in the harsh austerity of ascetics and harshness in the love of the fondly attached.

22. Ahalya was cursed by her husband sage Gautama to become a stone. On being touched by Lord Rama's feet, she again became a human being.

23. Vinoba is perhaps suggesting that knowledge can be imparted only when the teacher is worthy of imparting it and the pupil is worthy of receiving it, and the time is opportune for the process.

24. Uttarayan is the period of progress of the sun to the north (of the equator).

119. The worth of individual spiritual pursuit can be tested during collective spiritual pursuit. That helps in wearing down the corners of mind.

120. When I examine how much I have received from outside and how much is my own, I find that there is nothing in me which I can legitimately call my own. Hence, I have no reason to feel that "This is not mine".²⁵

121. When the Vedic sage says that "I want rice, I want wheat, I want pulses" etc., his 'I' includes the entire cosmos.

122. I do not aspire to become high like a hill. I would be happy if my ashes (after cremation) are scattered on the soil around.

123. 'A man of wisdom should behave as though he were dumb'—says a scriptural injunction. To behave so means to get absorbed in work.

124. Austerities involve three things: (i) purification of the mind, (ii) power of creativity and (3) spiritual knowledge. If, while practising austerities, one is not attached to the last two, all the three would be secured.

125. Study of history means a survey of our previous lives.

126. Lasting impression on others can be made through love alone. Whether the impression is good or bad depends upon its moral content.

127. Knowledge also is attainable through knowledge. In other words, it is possible to acquire further knowledge if there is some previous knowledge.

25. 'Idam na mama' in the original. These are the words said while making offering to the sacrificial fire.

128. Evil deeds should be killed. Good deeds should be injured. Renunciation of the fruits of action is the way to injure good deeds..

129. The joy in the effort excels the joy in the achievement.

130. Insistence is an important kind of strength. It is advisable not to expend it in trivial matters.

131. Free mind beyond the state in which the mind is transcended is the natural state.

132. The early hours of the morning are traditionally considered holy; then does it mean that all the other hours of the day are unholy? To a devotee, all hours should be equally holy.

133. The duty of a social reformer is to lead people a step further on the road to reform without losing the benefit of the labours by his predecessors.

134. *Sannyasa* means renunciation of five things: (i) absence of action, (ii) forbidden actions, (iii) actions arising out of desire, (iv) actions done with the intention of securing its fruit and (v) ego. Meaning of yoga is the same.

135. Regulation of diet means eating (i) the leftover after sacrifice and (ii) that which is pure, wholesome and conducive to good tendencies (iii) in a measured quantity (iv) without indulging the palate (v) after offering it to the Lord.

136. To renounce action is impossible. For, renunciation itself is an act.

137. 'To take *sannyasa*' has really no meaning. For, *sannyasa* itself means 'not to take.'

138. To try to secure the fruit of a good deed after its performance is like scooping up silt from the bed of the Ganga after diving into the river.

139. 'Before', 'after'—and similar prepositions in any language—are used with reference to both time and space. It indicates that a human being is naturally inclined to consider time and space as one.

140. "What was there before the world came into existence"?

"Absence of this question of yours!"

141. Taking a rope as a snake, a person takes to his heels in fright; another person takes a stick and goes on beating it. There is no difference between the two.²⁶

142. If it is not possible to discover God in this world, it is hopeless to search for Him outside and apart from it.

143. The phrase 'existence of the Self' is tautological. For, Self verily means existence.

144. O God! I do not want either worldly enjoyments or spiritual liberation. Give me instead the devotion for You. I do not seek supernatural powers or total absorption in meditation; give me an opportunity to serve.

145. One should not publicise when it is smouldering; the world will come to know of fire when the flames erupt.²⁷

146. The flash of lightning is like an assurance to the spiritual seeker. But he should not rely on it, satisfied with this glimpse. He should continue his efforts until he receives sunlight.

26. To consider a rope as a snake is an illusion. It gives rise to two reactions: to become afraid of the 'snake' and flee and to attack it. Both are senseless. What is necessary is to realize that it is a rope. This is what Vinoba appears to suggest.

27. Vinoba appears to suggest that a spiritual seeker should not advertise his spiritual pursuit; it will automatically be known after its consummation.

147. What I have taught my students is nothing in comparison to what I have learnt from them.

148. The attitude to say 'no' to anything should be firmly rejected.

149. A devotee of the goddess of liberty would be unable to cage a parrot.

150. The way of selfless action and the way of meditation (for realization of the Supreme) are compared to an ant and a bird respectively. I would compare the first with the tortoise and the second with the hare in the Aesop's fable. One may easily lose alertness during meditation, without being aware of it.

151. "Hey! Are you asleep?"

"No, not yet," replies one. "Yes, for a long time now," says another.

Whether you accept or reject, it means the same thing: you are not asleep. You may describe the Ultimate Reality as ॐ (Om) or as 'not this', 'not this', both mean the same.

152. To espouse the ideology of *advaita* (non-duality) is tantamount to establishing duality without fail.

153. Dream means wakefulness in sleep. Inadvertence means sleeping while being awake. Many a time these two states are cause and effect of each other.

154. A devotee entrusts worldly affairs, spiritual practice and also its fruition to God.

155. Belief in the authority of the Vedas means belief in the eternal validity of ethical religion.

156. How long should one continue spiritual practice? Until it begins to take place of its own accord.

157. Why is the Himalaya Mountain to the north?

Only because I have let it remain there. If tomorrow I walk over to its north, it will be to my south.

158. A seeker after God must keep a careful watch even on his dreams. This watchfulness is very useful for introspection and discovering one's true Self. King Harishchandra's story illustrates its necessity.²⁸

159. Fasting, regulated diet, natural diet.

160. Renunciation of any action on the only criterion that it results in pain is not proper. Renunciation of action because it results in pain may at times be proper.

161. The word 'creation' is an *anyokti*²⁹. It appears as creation, but it is really God.

162. Functions of poetry:

- (i) To sing the glory of God,
- (ii) To interpret the meaning of life,
- (iii) To point towards the direction of duty,
- (iv) To purify the mind.

163. The speech, which sticks to truth, is taken care of by the truth.

164. Reasoning (about the existence of God), experience (about His existence) and emergence of devotion for Him is a sequence similar to that of hearing about food, seeing it and actually eating it.

165. The saints have held even the goal of spiritual liberation as of no value. There are two objects behind this:

28. King Harishchandra gave away his kingdom to fulfil a promise given in a dream and suffered a lot subsequently.

29. *Anyokti* is a figure of speech which, by describing that which is not a subject-matter, conveys a reference to the subject-matter. Thus, when we say 'creation', we are indirectly referring to God and not what appears to be the creation.

- (i) To refurbish the concept of liberation by removing distortions in the idea, and
- (ii) To glorify spiritual pursuit.

166. The authors of mythologies and epics invented imaginary gods and eulogized them. They created imaginary demons and deprecated them. Thus, by avoiding direct references to human beings, they followed the precept that 'one should not call anyone good or bad' and indirectly achieved the object of inculcating moral ideas in the people. We should realize that these gods and demons reside in our own hearts.

167. God is like a playwright who writes a play and Himself joins the cast as one of the characters. God has composed the opera in the form of this universe and plays the role of the Self in it. "Having created that, He entered that itself."³⁰

168. What mainly distinguishes man from the animal is the power of speech. If we assume power of speech in the animal, we will have to assume in it the capacity for thinking also as in man. That is why it is the natural duty of man to keep his speech pure.

169. Vanaprasthashram signifies experience, mental equipoise and control of the sense organs.

170. One's own effort, blessing of elders, association with the saintly, grace of the preceptor, and will of God are the means in the spiritual pursuit.

171. Existence of God implies immortality of Self, which again means the eternal validity of dharma, which in turn signifies the blissfulness of life.

30. Taittireeya Upanishad. It says that Brahman created the world through penance and then entered it.

172. If during prayer, one closes one's eyes, one begins to doze off; if one keeps them open, there is no concentration. It is, therefore, desirable to keep them half closed, half open.

173. The house is on fire and yet this good fellow does not cry out for help, fearing what the people would say. What would the people say to this?

174. Vyasa wrote Vishnusahasranam (Thousand Names of Lord Vishnu). He has begun it with ॐ (Om). ॐ is the exceedingly abridged version of Vishnu-sahasranam.

175. When tired of keeping awake, man goes to sleep. When tired of sleeping, he gets up. *Rajas* and *tamas* are the consequences of each other.

176. Gayatri *mantra* is considered as a *mantra* for individual worship. But the expression 'dheemahi' (we meditate) denotes collectivity. It means that Gayatri worship is to be done by an individual, but while doing it, he should imagine himself as the representative of collectivity—the cosmic Self.

177. God is the embodiment of ideal: worthy of meditation, adoration and emulation.

178. As we are endowed with five senses, there are only five objects of senses in 'our' world. In reality, there are infinite objects of senses; or there are none at all.

179. It is asked, 'What is art?' In fact, the right question is, 'Whose art?' or 'Art of what?' And the answer is, 'Of the Self', which means that it is immortal, is beyond senses, but discernible to the intellect. The Self is beyond the intellect. Any creation is not art; it is either artistic or not.

180. Goodness is of two kinds: active and passive. Active goodness exerts itself. Passive goodness tends to let itself be carried away along the current. Active goodness

is useful in spiritual quest, while passive goodness makes worldly life tolerable.

181. "How is the existence of the Self proved?"

This very question of yours proves it.

If this reply of mine convinces you, then the fact that you are convinced proves it. If it does not, then the fact that you are not convinced proves it.

182. Association with virtuous and wise persons is the origin of my entire spiritual endeavour. I have such a fond attachment for their company that if a choice has to be made—which is really unlikely—between adherence to fundamental principles and association with the virtuous, I would be inclined to choose association with the virtuous.

183. Some say: 'God is unknowable'. If unknowable, how can they say that He exists? And if He exists, how can it be said that He is unknowable?

184. Action is as fuel to knowledge. In order to keep the fire of knowledge constantly burning, one must constantly supply the fuel in the form of action.

185. What are now words of authority for us were a matter of direct experience for the sages. It is, therefore, proper to test even the words of authority on the touchstone of experience.

186. Truth = *Dharma* = Brahman

187. Self-realization is the poetry in life.

188. You have already received the fruit; now only the performance of duty remains. How are you seeking the fruit again?

189. The Universe—Concrete, perceptible Brahman,
God—Inferential Brahman,
The Vedas—Brahman in the form of words,

The Self—Brahman.

190. It is as much imperative to apply the principle of non-possession to knowledge as to wealth. It is not proper to accumulate useless knowledge of sundry matters.

191. The Self is the embodiment of potentiality. Nothing is impossible for the Self.

192. However powerful the scientific instrument may be, it is useless for listening to the voice of the Self.

193. It is necessary to learn to differentiate between penance and self-mortification.

194. Constant remembrance of God means constant awareness of duties.

195. Renunciation of the fruit of actions symbolises complete surrender to God.

196. I feel that God's grace towards me is more than my devotion to Him.

197. *Abhyasa* (constant practice) and *vairagya* (dispassion) are respectively the positive and the negative aspects of one and the same thing.

198. Why should I stick to my *swadharma*?

—Not because it is dear to me, not because it is superior to that of others, but because my (spiritual) development is possible only through it.

199. Virtues or vices never come singly. They are usually accompanied by a number of related qualities to complete their work (of doing good or damage).

200. Just as a carpenter has faith in the principles of geometry, so should a servant of the people have faith in nonviolence and other vows.

201. Non-possession teaches one how to utilize to the maximum the minimum possible possessions.

202. Faith + *Prajna*³¹ + Energy and valour = Truth.

203. There can be nothing like individual well-being; well-being is essentially collective in nature.

204. First love, then sacrifice and at the end, peace.

205. Truth is the instrument for building all good qualities in a right manner.

206. Though a devotee may not have any knowledge, he can easily acquire it because of humility.

207. As the body progressively decays in the natural course, *prajna* should become increasingly steadfast. At the moment the body actually drops down, *prajna* should have reached its zenith. The Gita refers to such an end as death in the bright half of the month. On the other hand, death, occurring when the wisdom has degenerated along with the body, is death in the dark half of the month. (8.24, 25)

208. Hypocrisy is subtle. It is not that we are always conscious of it. It may reside in us even unnoticed. Many a time, a man is unconsciously hypocritical in his behaviour.

209. 'What does a dream indicate?' —

- i) The illusory character of all creation.
- ii) The power of imagination.
- iii) Incompleteness of the spiritual endeavour.

210. If the ethics which holds good in the case of an individual is found to be inapplicable to the community at large, then the doctrine of *advaita* (non-duality) would have to be considered untrue.

31. Often translated as 'wisdom', *prajna* denotes pure, mature, enlightened wisdom which makes one capable of perceiving truth and making right decisions.

- 211. i) Delight in words.
- ii) Delight in ideas.
- iii) Delight in experience.
- iv) Delight in faith.

212. It may be true that blood is thicker than water, but the holiness of water is uniquely its own.

213. I wish that the good qualities I possess should be in others also, because I possess them. I wish that the good qualities which I do not possess should be in others, because I do not possess them.

214. It is not necessary to go in search of a preceptor: for the preceptors themselves are in search of disciples. Our only task is to make ourselves fit to be disciples. It can be said that this itself amounts to the search of a preceptor.

215. Faith in God means faith in the world; that is, faith in the Self, which in turn means faith in Truth.

216. The fruit of all activity is a big zero. For, the sum total of all activity is to return ultimately to our original state.

217. A steady posture is good for meditation. Movement is good for reflection.

218. The Vedic sages do not fight shy of self-praise. What else could they, who have attained union with the Self, do? Could they praise the non-Self instead of the Self?

219. *Advaita* (non-duality) can be defined as the state in which duty and joy become one. But so long as we have not reached that state, our good lies in clinging to our duty.

220. Delving into the depths of the spirit affords such satisfaction as can never be obtained by the study of all literature or by the acquisition of the scientific knowledge about the whole universe.

221. It will bring no harm if, with the best of intentions, one poses as a seeker after spirit.

222. Darkness at night is conducive to reflection. That is its very purpose. It is useful to spend some time in reflection before going to sleep. This reflection must include a critical retrospection of one's conduct during the day, a resolve not to repeat the mistakes committed, and a prayer to God to that end. If possible, one should, at the time of reflection, try to see the star Dhruva.³² Dhruva is the deity of determination.

223. I define *japa*³³ as a verbal manifestation of the inner and constant contemplation of God, which cannot be contained within, and therefore overflows.

224. What are the means to make fate favourable?

(i) Efforts and (ii) prayer.

225. I observe silence at night. Perhaps because of that, darkness talks to me. It says, "You were born out of me and are going to get dissolved into me. Even today you are under my command."

226. The height of humility is beyond measurement.

227. There are three kinds of preceptors:

i) Those who instruct according to the capacity of the disciple and his deservingness,

ii) Those who instruct like a shower; without any discrimination, and

iii) Those who instruct through silence.

32. Dhruva, a mythological character, is supposed to have earned a permanent place in the sky through God's grace. He became the Pole star.

33. Repeated utterance of a Name of the Lord or a sacred verse.

228. One may have full comprehension of the Vedas, one may be lost into a contemplative trance for a while, remembrance of God's Name may arouse devotional fervour in one—what do all these matter? It is what seeps into conduct, which alone matters.

229. I felt relieved of responsibility the moment I was entrusted with a responsible job.

230. We rely upon the authority of the Vedic sages. The Vedic sages quote from sages who lived before them. The only conclusion that can be drawn from this is: "Knowledge exists from times immemorial."

231. If pursuit of the highest spiritual goal in life is considered difficult, we are afraid to move out to make an effort; if it is considered easy, we rush to the market to purchase it!

232. No nation can stand up and hold together as a nation unless its people are engaged in some form of continuous sacrifice.

233. To put up with grief is the beginning of endurance. The real test of endurance lies in enduring pleasures.

234. To pick up a mirror to find out what it is is one thing; to pick it up to look at one's face is another. Similarly, to study the Vedas to find out what they contain is one thing and to study the Vedas for Self-realization is another. The latter is termed '*swadhyaya*' (study of the Self).

235. Howsoever you may listen, that can never be an adequate substitute for reflection.

236. An action which entails much strain is never a *sattwik* action. And it is definitely not one's natural duty.

237. Whatever other harm there might be in hankering after service by transgressing our limits and the bounds of our *swadharma*, the main danger is that such service is not properly rendered.

238. Right use of intellect—*Sattva*
 Misuse of intellect—*Rajas*
 Non-use of intellect—*Tamas*.

239. The river Ganga is most useful to people because it flows along her definite course. But what would be the plight of the people if, obsessed by the idea of being more useful to people, she deflects from the determined course and starts flowing into the courtyards of people's houses?

240. The waves of the sea are in incessant commotion and at the same time they are engaged in a continuous recitation of the chant: ॐ (Om)! ॐ (Om)! ॐ (Om)! "Remember me constantly and fight on." (Gita, 8.7)

241. "Are you as sure of God's existence as of this lamp in front of us?"

—I firmly believe that God exists. As for the lamp in front of us, I cannot guarantee that it does in fact exist.

242. Life without thoughts
 Life full of thoughts
 Thought is life
 Life wherein thought has been transcended.³⁴

243. There is studied indifference in the alertness of a spiritual seeker, and there is alertness in his indifference.

244. A selfless and desireless doer is alert.
 A wise, Self-realised man is indifferent.
 A devotee is both alert and indifferent.

245. A preceptor would necessarily be a disciple. One who is not a disciple can never be a preceptor.

34. Vinoba is delineating here the successive stages in spiritual progress.

246. A preceptor should have reverence for the disciple; for discipleship is like a mother to the preceptorship.

247. Why should observation of the world around should give rise to any feeling other than respect, love or compassion?

248. If a person is unable to influence those who are near because they happen to know his faults, but appears to influence those who are far away as they do not happen to know his faults, then his influence on them is like a mirage. A mirage is better seen from a distance.

249. We should look upon our daily sleep as but a dress rehearsal of death. At the time of retiring to bed, we should daily practise the method of facing death prescribed by the scriptures.

250. He who can read Vedic verses in the leaves of the trees in front of him, has truly grasped the message of the Vedas.³⁵

251. No one can see the Self. If anyone becomes able to see it, he loses his power of speech and is unable to describe his experience. If he can describe it, it is difficult to find a listener. And even if he finds an indulgent listener, the listener can understand nothing.

252. It is difficult for a man of wisdom to live in this world and it is equally difficult for him to die. He, therefore, lives at the physiological level and dies at the psychological level.

253. It is the function of discriminating wisdom to reconcile love and dispassion.

35. Reference is obviously to the Gita, 15.1 ('With roots above and branches below, the banyan tree of worldly life is said to be imperishable. It has Vedic hymns for its leaves. One who knows it knows the Vedas.')

254. While awake, I experience three states of mind:
i) Devotion, ii) Moral alertness, iii) Utter nothingness.

255. A devotee of God relishes selfless and desireless action, as he looks upon it as worship.

256. The orthodox turns even worship into a ritualistic act. A devotee, on the other hand, converts even an ordinary act into an act of worship.

257. Egoism worries, "How can the world go on without me?"

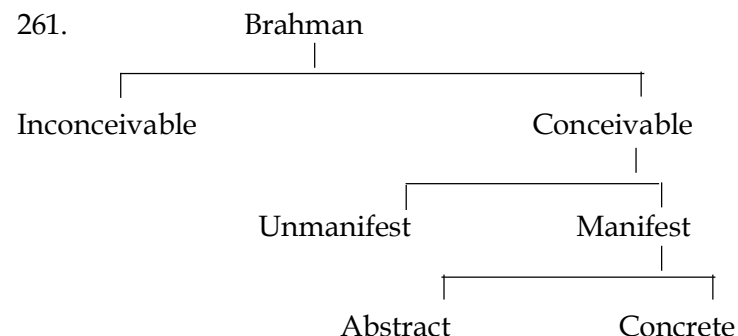
The fact is that the world can merrily go on even if, not only myself, but the whole world ceases to exist.

258. Even if you fail to keep up an attitude of worship while engaged in doing your activities, those activities will lead you to worldly prosperity. If you succeed in maintaining an attitude of worship, your activities will earn for you spiritual liberation.

259. "What would you do, if you were placed in my position?"

"Exactly the same as you are doing. For, your situation includes the state of your intelligence."

260. Merely intellectual knowledge is indirect. When it enters sense organs, it can be termed as direct knowledge.



262. One, who understands the nature of God's wrath, is freed from wrath. One who understands the nature of God's forgiveness becomes forgiving.

263. Modern science says that the body undergoes complete change every seven years.

The science of religion says that penance for twelve years completely cleanses the mind.

The science of spirituality says that knowledge of Brahman liberates the individual Self in an instant.

264. "Do unto others as you would be done by" is a true principle. Comparative psychology is a myth.

265. One should develop the feeling of having done nothing while serving others. One should develop the feeling of gratefulness while accepting service from others.

266. Those who put into practice the (spiritual) knowledge have given God a concrete form.

267. Had there been no sense organs (which serve as outlets), the individual, imprisoned in the body, would have been smothered. A liberated person has no need for the sense organs. A house cannot do without windows. Where is the need for windows to an open field?

268. All the various biological processes in the body are in a way functioning of the life-breath. But the process of articulation is its specially significant function. That is why the secret of *pranayama* (the process of breath-control) lies in restraint in speech.

269. (i) Listening to and reflection over spiritually useful matters,

(ii) Self-restraint and calming of the mind,

(iii) Sacrifice,

(iv) Practice of breath-control,

(v) Singing of devotional songs etc.

These, along with practices of similar kind are five means of spiritual pursuit.

270. If spiritual pursuit is considered a piece of sweet, (selfless) action is like its mass while reason is like sweetness. Sweetness is superior to mass. But that does not mean that mass can be discarded.

271. Meanings of silence:

- (i) Restraint in speech,
- (ii) Comprehension of truth,
- (iii) Conservation of energy,
- (iv) Aid to meditation.

272. *Sannyasa* (renunciation) is like a currency note, while *karmayoga* (the way of selfless and desireless action) is like a coin. The value of both is the same.

273. Reason tells what should be done, but it is difficult to put it into practice without unwavering resoluteness.

274. Pride within the bounds of morality is befitting and useful, as it is legitimate.

275. A coconut has hard exterior and soft kernel. One can realize the (spiritual) goal if there is dispassion outside and devotion inside.

276. Five kinds of pursuit:

- (i) Pursuit of what is dear,
- (ii) Pursuit of truth,
- (iii) Pursuit of equanimity,
- (iv) Pursuit of knowledge,
- (v) Pursuit of peace.

277. He who based the system of ethics on God has erected a structure on a firm foundation.

278. God is the synthesis of all that is good and auspicious.

279. A householder cannot be a teacher. For, he is tied down to other duties and is incapable of high idealism. A *sannyasi* can be an ideal teacher, but he belongs to the whole world and is not easily available to the pupils. Therefore, *vanaprashtha* is the only teacher available to the students as a right.

280. There can never be conflict between two religions. All religions are in conflict with irreligion.

281. It is God's will alone that exists; and also the will of one whose will is merged in that of God.

282. The saints possess dispassion, which leads them to spiritual liberation. Therefore, association with them provides restraint necessary in worldly pursuits. The sun burns white-hot, hence our bodies are kept warm at a temperature of 98 degrees F.

283. We are full of consciousness; yet we hanker after material things or succumb to their influence. What can one say about it?

284. True economics, true science of health—all true sciences are conducive to spiritual liberation.

285. The creation is like *arati* (waving of light before the Lord's image after the worship). The worship is over. What remains is our bowing to the Lord.

286. The Self alone is what joins the past, present and future.

287. Bhavabhooti³⁶ says, "Flowers are not to be trampled under feet; their right place is on the head."

True. Their right place is, indeed, on the head; but on the head of the tree-goddess, not on ours.

36. A famous Sanskrit dramatist.

288. Do not surmise that you are not going to die because you have not died until now. Infer instead that you will have to die because you have not died until now.

289. To look after the universe is the God's business; it is His special duty to look after the wretched.

290. Nothing is mine. Everything is mine. I belong to everyone.

291. One should not hanker after guiding humanity at the cost of fundamental principles.

292. Renunciation repays the capital of sin (of original accumulation). Charity just pays the interest on it.

293. Which is 'the fierce austerity not ordained by the scriptures' that the Gita refers to? (17.5)

—The worldly life marked by attachment to sensual pleasures.

294. Social science says, "It is a duty to protect your rights."

Dharma says, "It is your right to continue to do your duty."

295. However small may be the means, the intensity (in spiritual pursuit) will save you.

296. Determinants of action:

i) Occasion, ii) *Prarabdha*³⁷ and iii) Wisdom.

37. According to the law of karma, we have to suffer the consequences of our actions—in subsequent births if not in the present one. One can be liberated only when the pool of actions gets exhausted through suffering. The past actions brought forward in our account are many. We take the present birth to suffer the wages of a part of those actions. This is the *prarabdha karma*. The moment it is exhausted through suffering, existence of the present body comes to an end.

297. The answer to the question "Who am I"? determines the duty.

298. There is no separate room for air in the house. Air is needed in all the rooms. Similarly, *dharma* does not have a separate realm. It must pervade all human affairs.

299. When planted in soil, a sapling receives sustenance from it. Similarly, when the mind is firmly planted in the Self, it receives sustenance from it.

300. We do not have to decide our *swadharma*, as we had not, as it were, fallen from the sky. We are part of the stream of existence. That determines our *swadharma*.

301. If it is possible for Satan to quote the Bible³⁸, then surely the Bible also must share some blame.

302. It is quite easy to devise a plan for unifying the whole world. But it is difficult to achieve victory over anger in one's own mind.

303. Where there is sacredness, there is beauty. Where there is beauty, there is poetry.

304. The measure of the power of God depends upon the measure of the power of Self.

305. The word '*para*' (in Sanskrit) means 'the other', while the word '*param*' means 'distinguished and superior'. A spiritual seeker looks upon others as distinguished and superior to him.

306. Like air currents, spiritual currents are also blowing in the sky. These latter originate from liberated souls. It is by their imperceptible touch that an urge for spiritual emancipation is created among those in bondage.

38. In the original, the reference is to the Bhagavata.

307. A devotee lives on the vital level. This implies that he does not live on the mental level. In other words, he gives up all passions.

308. Sacrifice that gives rise to pride is no sacrifice. Sacrifice ought to lead to inner peace. If I abandoned a room filled with noxious air, what special have I done? I have only secured the peace of my mind. Ultimately, giving up of pride is the true sacrifice.

309. The road appears an impediment when we are eager to reach the destination. It should, however, not be forgotten that the road itself is the means of reaching the destination. If one is anxious to reach the destination as early as possible, one should walk briskly.

310. However learned a man may be, if his knowledge is confined to the body, the depth and measure of that knowledge is quite obvious.

311. Utility is the body of religion; purification of heart is its soul.

312. In the words of Jnanadeva, the message of the Gita is ever new. What is always new is everlasting.

313. Arjuna asks the Lord, "Why does one commit sin even though one does not want to commit it?"

The Lord replies, "One commits it because one wills it!"

314. The Vedas declare, "The Supreme is One". But at the same time also say, "The sages describe it variously." They are not prepared to say, "The stupid describe it variously." This shows their spirit of non-opposition.

315. (i) Purification of mind, (ii) Service to the motherland, (iii) Universal love, (iv) Worship of God.

316. The feeling that every kind of good work has to be undertaken as a matter of duty is a disease that affects persons of *sattwic* nature.

317. "If you are unable to give up a life of indulgence of the senses, then enjoy the pleasures at least in the name of God."

"If you are unable to give up a life of indulgence of the senses, then do not at least enjoy the pleasures in the name of God."

318. Body—*Tamas*
Sense organs—*Rajas*
Reason—*Sattva*
Self—Beyond all attributes.

319. There are two kinds of supernatural powers: (i) Those that promote dispassion and (ii) Those that help secure power and wealth.

The former are conducive to spiritual liberation, while the latter are a hindrance to it.

320. The study has to have three dimensions: length, breadth and depth.

Length—a long period
Breadth—unbroken continuity
Depth—attention

321. If reverence for those possessing some excellences or good qualities be termed as worship of the concrete, then endeavour for imbibing those excellences or good qualities would be considered as worship of the abstract.

322. *Advaita* (non-dualism) implies that "what is yours is yours and what is mine is also yours." For, my knowledge of non-dualism applies to me, not to others.

323. Indolence, ignorance and lack of faith are three great enemies.

324. Do not be scared by the depth of this sea of worldly life. You have only to swim over its surface, is not it? Or, do you intend to get drowned in it?

325. To work in the interest of all living beings is *nirguna* (abstract) worship. It is not proper to take it as an external yardstick of morality and compare it to welfarism.

326. Service to people is a humble duty. Organising people and leading them on the right path is a great privilege.

327. There are four states of the Self:

(i) When it is attached to the body, it is the state of bondage.

(ii) When it realizes its separateness from the body, it is the state of enlightenment.

(iii) When it transcends the bounds of body, it is the state of purity.

(iv) When it is without body, it is the state of liberation.

328. The vast universe, comparatively limited human society and the specific human body are three entities which are congenital to man. They cause bondage to him. And it is through them that the path to spiritual liberation passes.

329. Not only the sun, but its reflection in water also radiates light. Not only knowledge, but its semblance also commands respect.

330. The Himalayas are majestic. But my idea of their majesty is more beautiful. What could be the reason for this? How could the grandeur of an inanimate thing compete with the grandeur of the Self?

331. Altruistic deeds can lead to the purification of mind, but only if they have been performed without vanity.

332. Shankaracharya says, "Sayings in the scriptures are open to many interpretations." It means that they can bear with *any* number of critical interpretations, but *not any kind* of interpretation.

333. The fact that spiritual knowledge can be comprehended only if you have some knowledge is a proof of the theory of rebirth. This in turn implies the immortality of the Self.

334. Attachment of those having attachment (to persons or worldly affairs) will not prove immortality of the Self. For, attachment is born of illusion. Non-attachment of the dispassionate provides real evidence of the immortality of the Self.

335. It is the business of sophists to dismiss both nonviolence and truth by justifying violence for the sake of truth on some occasions and by justifying untruth for the sake of nonviolence on others.

336. I can imagine lack of Self-knowledge even though nonviolence etc. are being practised. But it is difficult for me to believe that even after the dawn of Self-knowledge, nonviolence etc. may not be practised.

337. If one gives up the pride of family, one is free from attachment to the home. Leaving one's home or collapse of the house is not necessary for this purpose. Similarly, if one gives up the egoistic identification with the body, one should be free from attachment to the body. There is no reason why it should be necessary to leave the body or that the body should drop.

338. When love gets transferred from mother to wife and from wife to son, it is degeneration of love. If it gets transferred from mother to saints and from saints to God, then it is sublimation of love.

339. Creation of any agitation in the universe or its subsiding can have no effect on a person who has attained the state of identity with God.

340. The various deities embody different attributes of only one God.

341. Three-fold purification:

- (i) Purification of thought,
- (ii) Purification of mind,
- (iii) Purification of conduct.

342. We try to 'utilize' even saints and sages. But we cannot help that their teaching is difficult to digest.

343. I see fog at a distance. Another person sees it around me. In fact, fog is everywhere. I imagine that the condition of other person is satisfactory. He imagines that my condition is satisfactory. In fact, there is contentment everywhere. Only that one has to realize this.

344. If one fears (temptations) in life, death would lose its dreadfulness.

345. In childhood, I used to be extremely upset while immersing the image of Ganesha. The idea of immersing it in water after installing it so lovingly and worshipping for many days was unbearable. But Hindu dharma has laid this down to bring home the limits of image worship.

346. New currency is introduced invariably with the coronation of a new king. Similarly, a new terminology is bound to evolve with the emergence of a new philosophy of life.

347. To think that one knows is a sign of ego. To think that one does not know anything is also a sign of ego.

348. Playing with the interpretation of scriptures is a great sin in the Kaliyuga (the modern age).

349. Man becomes poor first; wealth leaves him only afterwards.

350. A devotee uses in his spiritual endeavour any means which the natural course of events offers him. A yogi creates a situation favourable for his spiritual endeavour. Both, however, have to adopt both the courses so far as is practicable.

351. A *karmayogi* (selfless and desireless doer) is like a burnt cow-dung cake which has retained its shape (form.)

A *sannyasi* (renunciate) is like a burnt cow-dung cake which has become a formless pile of ashes.

352. A *karmayogi* is like a black cow, which gives white milk.

A *sannyasi* is like a white cow, which gives white milk.

353. A *karmayogi* works incessantly like the sun.

A *sannyasi* is always a detached non-doer of actions like the sun.

354. The masses may be ignorant, but they are as accurate in judging the real worth (of public men) as a clinical thermometer is in ascertaining the body temperature.

355. There was a she-buffalo in our ashram. She used to suckle her own calf as well as any other calf, even of a cow. Some of us used to call her stupid. I learnt from her that one should have even-mindedness.

356. There is also a reason for considering the more and more unevolved consciousness (spirit) as superior.

357. Pronunciation in the Sanskrit language appears to have been affected by the attitude of the sages to have equal regard for all.

358. Actions that take place after the attainment of spiritual knowledge are only apparently so. Even as a person's shadow does not disturb his solitude, such actions should not disturb the solitude of Self-knowledge.

359. The potency in the repetition of the Lord's Name is more than that in the Vedic hymns. The Lord's Name can be invested with limitless power.

360. When I placed dispassion and detachment in one of the two pans of a balance and the rest of all that is known as *sattvik* in the other pan, I found that dispassion weighed more.

361. The sum total of Valmiki's genius, Vyasa's wisdom and Shuka's love can become a small unit for measuring the extent of divinity.

362. From the joys and sorrow that one experiences in dreams it is possible to have an idea of the pleasures and pains that the individual self has to experience in the subtle body after death.

- (i) Death—Sleep.
- (ii) The subtle body—Dreams.
- (iii) The heaven—Pleasures experienced in dreams.
- (iv) The hell—Pains experienced in dreams.
- (v) *Brahmaloka* (the abode of Brahman)—Profound sleep.
- (vi) Rebirth—Reawakening.

363. God in His incarnation as Rama accepted abundant service from others. In His incarnation as Krishna, He rendered great service to others.

364. There is no terminus for a man who chooses to go round and round; or, alternatively, there is a terminus wherever he chooses to sit down.

365. The possibility of the use of similes and metaphors is a natural proof of the underlying unity in the universe. Also, it is on the veracity of this doctrine of non-dualism that all worship is based.

366. Quietism that opposes activity is not true quietism. It is a kind of activity. True quietism is that which can easily accommodate activity within itself.

367. Asceticism is nothing but vanquished *rajas*. The vigorous ebullience in spiritual endeavour stems from it.

368. Four forces are fighting sin in their own ways:

- (i) Meritorious deeds,
- (ii) Suffering to atone the sin,
- (iii) Expiation and,
- (iv) Self-knowledge.

369. Whatever stands in opposition to truth would naturally be proved to be false.

370. It is not only a historical truth that Rama, the wielder of the bow, protected the sages from demons who put obstacles in their religious sacrifices; but it is also an eternal truth.

371. Regulation of the instinctive desire for food is the aim behind the institution of *yajna* (religious sacrifices).

372. Reason is the main gateway to the vision of the Self. Once the gateway is opened, the Self within stands revealed.

373. The nature of any deity is spiritual. The Sun-god, for example, stands for inspiration; the Water-goddess for faith; the House-goddess for stability and steadfastness; the Sylvan goddess for liberty and so on.

One, who worships any of these deities with faith but without realizing their nature, may achieve ordinary purification of heart; but its special and superior purification depends on the knowledge of the nature of the deity worshipped.

374. Spiritual attainment is the test for the extent of purification. It may take several births to pass this test. A patient may feel that he has very high fever, but it is the thermometer alone which ascertains the exact temperature.

375. The object of *sannyasa ashram* (the fourth stage in life) is to institute a collective experiment in the practice of renunciation, even as we have undertaken a

collective experiment of satyagraha.³⁹ Though the collective experiment lacks the glorious and unique intensity of the individual effort, it has its own glory because of extensiveness.

376. That we do not remember past lives is God's design to obviate humiliation of the Self because of memories of virtues and vices therein.

377. Worldly life is compared to a sea. Just as a man drowning in a sea must not lose a single moment but start swimming instantly, similarly must a man make an immediate effort to free himself from this worldly life.

378. *Karma* (selfless and desireless action) is actual service; *bhakti* (devotion) is the disposition to serve.

379. The sound of a flute can remind me of Lord Krishna and induce in me a meditational trance. But

- (i) it should be a dark moonless night,
- (ii) identity of the player should not be known, and
- (iii) the sound should come from afar.

This is because of the power of the unmanifest.

380. Passions would not get firmly rooted in the mind, if any outward actions emanating from it are resolutely avoided.

381. Discriminative wisdom in the dispassion is the strength of dispassion.

382. The sight of the sea is delightful, but only to an onlooker on the shore, not to one who is drowning in it.

383. The higher one climbs on a hill, the greater is the grandeur of the scene. Grandeur of thought depends on the level of conduct.

39. Under Gandhi's leadership during the struggle for Indian Independence.

384. Service of an enduring nature is incapable of being indicated specifically.

"That which cannot be destroyed and cannot be indicated (Imperishable and Indefinable)."⁴⁰

385. The concept of attributeless Supreme keeps the worship of the Supreme with attributes within proper limits. Otherwise, the latter would become flawed.

386. The whole universe around us is none else but God Vishnu Himself in deep sleep. He has to be awakened entreatingly with love and reverence.

387. The interpretation which adheres both to the letter and spirit is the true one. One who is well-versed in the scriptural texts and also well-advanced in spiritual wisdom which transcends the word, is alone able to arrive at such an interpretation.

388. It takes both warriors and statesmen to win a war. In a satyagraha, nonviolence is the warrior and truth is the statesman.

389. *Rajas* has indeed obliged us by being fickle by nature. Had it been stable, there would have been no end to the disaster it would have caused.

390. There is no concentration without the quality of *sattva*. *Tamas* is incapable of concentrating on anything, while *rajas* is led away by too many distractions.

391. When *rajas* and *tamas* are completely annihilated, *sattva* virtually dies, even though it remains alive.

392. The *mantras* like the Gayatri *mantra* are supposed to be chanted in a subdued tone, as if muttered to one's own self. It is for the same purpose as keeping the eyes half-closed while meditating.

40. Gita, 12.3. This is part of the description of Brahman.

393. Highest principles are applicable and beneficial to all; hence they can be easily grasped by all.

394. The actions by a detached seeker neither originate in the hill of egoism nor merge ultimately in the sea of the fruit of actions. Yet they go on enthusiastically like the waves of a mirage.

395. All work is accomplished by God's will alone, but out action is like a vehicle to God's will.

396. God descends both as Time Spirit and in the form of a human being to establish dharma and the fundamental principles.

Time Spirit indicates the impossibility of unrighteousness. The incarnation as a human being shows that unrighteousness is undesirable.

397. Form resides in a thing; a thing does not reside in the form. And even in a thing, form is not something apart from it. This is a real miracle.

398. Co-ordination of reason and emotion constitutes the faculty of discernment and discretion.

399. What has one, who fails to see the knower of the body in the body, seen also of the body itself? What has one, who has failed to notice the flame in the lamp, seen of the lamp itself?

400. For the same reason as the injunction, "Breathe constantly", and the prohibition "Do not walk on your head" are not applicable to me, the moral do's and don'ts are not applicable to a man of spiritual wisdom. For him, moral behaviour is natural, while what is prohibited does not take place of its own accord.

401. Meditation is a temporary device to ward off the blow of worldly affairs on us. Spiritual knowledge enables us to attack the world and wound it fatally and permanently. To put away the phenomenal world

temporarily is the function of meditation. To learn to look upon the world as Brahman constitutes spiritual knowledge.

402. Threefold duty:

- i) Commitment to truth
- ii) Endeavour for righteous conduct
- iii) Study of the Self through remembrance of God.

403. Truth is greater than even the saints. The saints have originated from a mere fraction of Truth.

404. While breathing out there is a sound similar to 'सो' ('so...') like that of steam let out by an engine, and while inhaling, the breath makes a sound similar to 'हम्' ('ham') like a man's voice resounding under a dome. The chant 'सोऽहम्' ('Soham') (literally, 'I am He, that is, Brahman') is not based on this factor alone; that similarity is only an outward indication. The spiritual purpose behind the respiratory process is to cleanse the narrow consciousness in the physical body through the sense of vastness in the universe. The chant 'सोऽहम्' ('Soham') indicates this purpose and that is why it is based on the respiratory process.

405. Silence of an angry man is no real evidence of his silence. It only shows that he is angry. If an angry man speaks, it does not demonstrate his power of speech; it is an evidence of his anger.

Actions of a man of spiritual wisdom do not prove that he is the doer of them, they show his wisdom. Abstention from action on the part of such a man does not show lack of action, it shows his wisdom.

406. A man of spiritual wisdom performs not only those acts which he actually performs, but also those which he does not perform. He is, therefore, a perfect *karmayogi* (doer of selfless and desireless action).

A man of spiritual wisdom not only does not perform those acts which he does not perform, but he is not the doer of those acts also which he does perform. He is, therefore, a perfect *sannyasi* (a man of renunciation).

407. Forbearance denotes the endeavour to pour the sense of discrimination established in the reason into the sense organs.

408. One and the same river flows through many places. Same is the case with the Self.⁴¹

409. Scriptures tell you what to do; they do not forcibly make you do that. This is their limitation; and in it lies their greatness.

410. Yoga is natural for a devotee. For, a mind that is completely filled with thoughts of God has naturally no room for entertaining thoughts about objects of the senses.

411. What remains behind if we remove from a thing all its visible and invisible attributes?

One says, "Nothing." Another says, "The individual distinctiveness." The third says, "The unknowable." The Vedas say, "The Supreme Spirit."

412. The essence of yoga:

(i) *Yama*⁴² (ii) *Niyama*⁴³ (iii) *Samyam*⁴⁴.

41. What this appears to mean is that the Self takes different physical bodies (in different births).

42. Five moral values or rules of conduct, which are social observances. They are: truth, nonviolence, non-stealing, non-possession and brahmacharya.

43. Rules of conduct which are individual observances. They are: purity, contentment, austerity, study of the Self and dedication to the Lord.

44. Self-restraint.

413. An individual's sense of separate identity can be dedicated to God only after it has become submerged in the sense of separate identity in the collectivity. Purification must precede dedication.

414. Spiritual knowledge which is most ancient is the best. Mode of worship which is latest is the best.

415. The food that is consumed is transformed into three kinds of energy—sexual energy, vital energy and spiritual energy—depending on the attitude of the eater.

416. Social sciences such as economics, sociology etc. are not regulative, but regulated sciences. They cannot but accept any regulation which I choose to impose upon them.

417. Water of itself cannot drown me. It can drown me only if I get into it. Even there, it cannot drown me so long as I keep on swimming; it can drown me only when, out of fatigue, I give up swimming. Even then, it can drown me only if I have identification with my body, not otherwise. This is what freedom of the Self means.

418. Who is a saint? He, to me, is a saint in whom I do not find, or find in a very small measure, the particular blemish or failing which I happen to have. There is no need for me to think more about this.

419. That Brahman is Truth can be proved. Brahman as consciousness can be discerned. Brahman as bliss catches the eye. The universe, the individual self and the saints illustrate this, in this order.

420. Old practices are not to be blindly followed; but they should receive careful consideration.

421. It is possible to attain spiritual liberation while being encased in the physical body; but it is improbable.

422. The machine of *karmayoga* should be kept in the perfect condition. One should not be slack while operating

it for fear of friction; to avoid friction, lubricant in the form of devotion should be put in.

423. A spiritual seeker should avoid three irregular roads, namely, avoiding our duty, undertaking the duty that is not incumbent on us and a secondary duty. He should take to the road of *swadharma*.

424. While putting into practice the philosophy of selfless action, regulation of time, regulation of the choice of work and restraint on flights of imagination are essential.

425. The propriety of any action has to be judged by examining the intention (of the doer), consequences and the nature of action.

426. There are two demerits in being blindly attached to the flesh: (i) extroversion and (ii) narrowness of outlook. The former takes the God within away from us; the latter results in alienation from the world around.

427. Righteousness acts in two ways. At times, it conserves; at times, it explores. Inclusive righteousness brings about reconciliation of previous experiences, while exploratory righteousness discovers something new.

428. 'Education means association with the good people.'—I am unable to define education more appropriately than this.

429. In the religion I envisage, worship is optional, and hence imperative.

430. The vulnerability of the sense of attachment to 'me and mine' lies in the fact that a man thereby loses his sovereign power.

431. *Upasana* (worship) means sitting near God. In other words, bringing God wherever one happens to be sitting.

432. The scientific way of thinking consists in observing the world first and then arriving at generalizations through induction. The spiritual way of non-thinking believes that the world is bound to conform to the principle that suggests itself in the state of *samadhi*.⁴⁵

433. A man is like a lamp. His virility is like oil. The life-breath is the wick and his wisdom, the flame.

"Hail to thee, o Light"!

434. There are many types of *samya* (equalities and identities). But amongst them all, identity with Brahman, the Absolute, is the ultimate and supreme *samya*.

435. If one experiences something genuinely, that should be considered true. But this does not mean that the conclusions of the experiencer should be considered valid.

436. Longing to know the truth is the most efficacious means in the spiritual pursuit. And inner peace is the true achievement.

437. A spiritual seeker should be like fire. Discriminating reason is its light and dispassion is its heat.

438. It is the function of non-possession to clear the useless clutter from the mind and make it empty.

439. In the Vedas, the root 'सह' (*sah*) has two meanings: to endure and to win. One who endures, wins.

440. Humility means resilience. In resilience, there is the power to withstand strain, the art of winning and the height of bravery.

441. Four steps in (spiritual) knowledge: (i) comprehension, (ii) perseverance, (iii) absorption and (iv) wisdom.

45. A state of complete absorption in Divine consciousness.

442. *Yajna* (sacrifice) primarily maintains the balance of natural forces, *dana* (charity) maintains the balance of social forces and *tapas* (austerities) maintains the balance of mental forces.

443. Oh goddess of dawn! You are the very embodiment of *sattwa*. Who else but you can deliver the mind, caught between the day marked by *rajas* and night marked by *tamas*?

444. Success should induce humility and failure should result in enthusiasm—that is what the philosophy of detached action dictates.

445. The scriptures say that God is full of love. This is the foundation of the way of devotion.

446. The Vedas have described God as '*suroopa-krutnu*' (Creator of beauty). How much beautiful must He Himself be who has created this beautiful universe?

447. By not letting a person with little faith sustain himself in spiritual endeavour, people actually oblige him.

448. A spiritual seeker reaches such a stage in his spiritual endeavour that he needs some prop to proceed further. Without it, he loses his patience, his resolve becomes shaky and his reason is assailed by doubts. This is the hour of his test.

449. Of all gifts, freedom from fear ranks the highest. And no one except a liberated soul, in other words God, is capable of making such a gift.

450. Mastery over dreams is of two kinds—

(i) Attaining to the state wherein one sees only good dreams,

(ii) Attaining to the state wherein one sees no dreams at all.

Mastery over sound sleep means constant development of thoughts in sound sleep.

451. When one has transcended one's mind, there is no cognition of the creation. In the natural state of awareness, cognition is and yet is not there. The state wherein mind is transcended is for a particular time. The natural state of awareness is abiding.

452. A person who subtracts slander from praise and praise from slander frees himself automatically from either burden.

453. The true meaning of non-possession is the dissolution of identification with one's body. For, the body itself is the main possession.

454. The final resultant of all completely selfless service, rendered with all available power of love while residing in the body, is described by the negative word 'non-violence.'

455. If it were possible to liken God to some object, would not that object itself become God? How can a painter be likened to his painting?

456. The crowing of a cock is (i) high-pitched, (ii) gentle, (iii) phased and (iv) tremulous.

The attitude of one wanting to awaken others should be the same.⁴⁶

457. It is in the very nature of saints 'to go astray' (in the conventional sense) and lead others the same way. Moreover, it is in fact their special life-mission to lead the youth 'astray'.

458. Enjoyment of worldly pleasures and spiritual liberation are two ends of one and the same stick.

46. Vasant Nargolkar interprets this as follows: He should be (i) full of intense zeal, (ii) gentle in his approach, (iii) proceed gradually and (iv) be full of compassion.

459. Not all problems can be solved by trying to solve them. Some problems are automatically solved by leaving them alone.

460. So long as the eyes have not imbibed the underlying non-duality among all objects in the world, it will not be safe to believe their judgement as regards beauty.

461. During spiritual quest, (i) *udyoga*—constant endeavour and (ii) *prayoga*—experimentation.

After spiritual attainment, *yoga*—harmonized action with detachment.

462. Aeons passed before the first spark struck the fuel. However, on that basis one need not calculate the time required for its reduction to ashes.

463. Concentration of the mind is not the final stage in the practice of yoga. It is its starting point.

464. One who sees God before one's eyes has attained spiritual wisdom. But it is enough for a seeker to have the faith stabilized that there is God behind him (to protect him under all circumstances).

465. It is not necessary to construct a road for fire to pass through a forest by cutting the forest down. It manages to make its own way. For a devotee, circumstances are never adverse.

466. A devotee with an intense longing is like the heart of God, a seeker after knowledge is like His intellect, a seeker after the well-being of all is like His hand and a man of spiritual wisdom is like His soul.

467. Philosophy is to religion what seed is to a tree. The minutest variation in the seed assumes large proportions in the tree. It is, therefore, necessary that there should be subtlety and precision in philosophical thought.

468. A direct touch of God is needed to assuage the inner yearning; even the slightest distance is difficult to bear. Can thirst be quenched if a glass of water is held very near the lips?

469. The momentum of devotional fervour generated by prayer is more important than the prayer itself. This momentum is a yardstick to measure the depth of the prayer.

470. There are two types of dispassion: one is driven by a desire (of spiritual attainment) and the other is without (such) desire. The former is based on the conviction that worldly pleasures are transient, while the latter is based on the conviction that worldly pleasures are no pleasures at all.

471. Types of penance:

- (i) That which is undertaken out of ignorance,
- (ii) That which is undertaken for sensual gratification,
- (iii) That which is undertaken out of hypocrisy,
- (iv) That which is undertaken out of obstinacy,
- (v) That which is undertaken as part of asceticism,
- (vi) That which is undertaken out of love, and
- (vii) That which is rooted in spiritual knowledge.

472. Waiting in expectation and philosophical indifference are complementary emotions. A spiritual aspirant needs both on appropriate occasions.

473. Through individual prayer, I secure God's help; through collective prayer, that of the saints.

474. What is blind faith? It is the faith in the absolute supremacy of logical reasoning.

475. Hindu dharma has devised the celebration of Holi⁴⁷ for providing an opportunity to practise the vow of non-possession.

47. The festival of fire in which waste is burnt.

476. It was the good fortune of the Upanishadic sages that their works have survived, but not their names as authors. This could not have been possible without complete effacement of the sense of separate individuality.

477. When two points are decided, the course of the straight line is settled. Similarly, the points of individual self and the Supreme Self decide the course of spiritual endeavour.

478. There is no room for human enterprise in fatalism, so it is to be rejected. There is no humility in the belief in self-reliance, so it is to be rejected.

There is humility in fatalism, so it should be accepted. Belief in self-reliance entails efforts, so it should be accepted.

479. (Spiritual) Knowledge is like a sacred chant. Action is the technique. Worship joins the two.⁴⁸

480. The sleeping Self will be awakened only when we spur it through penance and keep on reciting resoundingly the holy Name.

481. How far have I understood God's art? And to whatever degree I may have understood it, am I also not an artistic creation of God?

482. There is no religious injunction for compulsory idol worship. But there is certainly a prohibition of iconoclasm.

483. *Sannyasa* (renunciation) and *yoga* (action with non-attachment) are two tongues of one and the same fire of spiritual knowledge.

48. It appears to mean that knowledge provides theoretical foundation and inspiration to a spiritual seeker, while action is needed to proceed towards the destination. Spiritual pursuit needs both.

484. The sun carries with it its light, wherever it goes. The same must be the case with a person dedicated to service. The spirit of service must accompany him wherever he is and whatever he is doing from moment to moment.

485. The act of respiration goes on through all the pores in the body, but mainly through the nostrils. If good deeds are likened to the pores, worship is like the nostrils.

486. A servant of the people is forbidden to poke his nose into their private affairs without being called upon to do so.

487. An idol, which is not accessible to all for worship, cannot, according to the science of idol worship, be the embodiment of God.

488. Blessed is the land of birth of divine incarnations, the land where the saints are laid to final rest and the land which is the field of heroic action by the brave.

489. O Mother! Let only one word resound in the ears of this child of yours, 'Self! Self! Self!'

490. The good qualities of both sleep and wakefulness together constitute a state of *samadhi*, while their bad qualities constitute a dream.

491. Existence of virtues should be accepted as axiomatic, while the existence of vices should be accepted only after they are proved.

492. The Self 'cannot be killed'. Why? Because 'it does not kill'.⁴⁹

493. What is the primary religion of human beings?—Cultivation of humanness.

49. Reference is to the Gita, 2.19, which says that the Self neither slays nor is ever slain.

494. If a person sleeps in a room with the door closed, the sun comes to serve him, but waits at the door. It does not enter the room forcibly. But the moment the door opens, even if slightly, it enters the room without fail. This is how a servant of the people should remain within his bounds and be ever ready to serve.

495. *Bhiksha*⁵⁰ means reliance on God. In other words, it implies faith in the goodwill of the society, or contentment with whatever one gets by chance, or devotion to one's duty and an attitude of indifference to the fruits of action.

496. The eye can see straight only. Let the mind learn this from the eye.

497. Euclid says, 'The shortest distance between two points is the straight line that joins them.' Truth stands firm on this empirical observation.

498. Self-restraint means conservation of psychical powers.

499. Freedom from arrogance is the last among the Divine tendencies (enumerated in the sixteenth chapter of the Gita). It means lack of pride even when all the other Divine tendencies have been ingrained.

500. Through self-purification, foreign matter is either thrown out or it is converted into the matter of the same kind and is then assimilated.

501. The coward and the cruel are one and the same.

502. Utilitarianism takes its own utility for granted!

50. Literally, alms. But it refers not to the alms sought by beggars, but by the *sannyasins* and the like who have renounced the world for spiritual quest, and are not engaged in any work for livelihood. As their quest benefits the society, it is considered a sacred obligation to give them alm.

503. I see God's flowing compassion in a river.

504. What is theoretical (*tattvik*) is abstract, like the head concerned with airy subtleties.

What is pure (*sattvik*) is concrete, like the feet touching the solid earth.

505. Spiritual quest commences from despondency. The first chapter of the Gita is titled 'The yoga of despondency.'

506. To purify the mind, penance is like a soap and devotion is like water.⁵¹

507. The following three topics must necessarily form part of any complete philosophy:

(i) Consideration of what ought to be done and what ought not to be done.

(ii) Consideration of cause and effect.

(iii) Consideration of action and its doer (agent).

508. The purposes behind the work which a spiritually enlightened person appears to do are:

(i) To show right path to the people.

(ii) To exhaust *prarabdha*.⁵²

(iii) To judge his spiritual progress.

(iv) To derive delight in a natural way.

509. Would a person complain if he happens to drop a piece of live coal from his hand? Worldly life is like a piece of live coal in one's hand. One should discard it happily to pursue the objective of spiritual attainment.

51. Devotion would be able to purify the mind to some extent, but purification would be more if penance complements devotion.

52. See footnote 37

510. Some call this universe '*maya*' (illusion), some describe it as '*lila*' (Divine play), while some others refer to it as '*sphoorti*' (vibrant manifestation of the Supreme). What is wrong if one remains silent?

511. Rather than opposing a negative thing with its opposite positive thing, it is better to be indifferent to the former.

512. Reflection on the Self means reflection on the power of the Self. The Self is, in fact, unthinkable.

513. Destruction is a necessary part of development. But one should test this hypothesis on one's own self.

514. "Do the qualities such as nonviolence belong to matter or to spirit?"

Nonviolence etc. are qualities of neither the matter, nor the spirit. They are inherent properties of the spirit.

515. An incarnation of God comes to be universally revered. It should be considered a great fortune, if even a dog chooses to keep company with an ascetic.

516. The way of detached and selfless action is not *rajas* (activism); it is an antidote to it.

517. If knowledge of the material world is not ignorance, it may be the source of wealth and authority. But it certainly is not knowledge in the true sense.

518. One view: The world is not meant for righteous people; therefore, they should keep aloof from worldly affairs.

Another view: The world is meant for righteous people alone; so they should have patience.

What it means is that the world may or may not be for righteous people, they should never give up their righteousness.

519. Were it not for the impossibility of leading a life of flawless sacrifice, there would have been no need for devotion (to God).

520. You say, "This is final and irrefutable, because it is proved by experiment."

I say, "It is tentative and refutable for the very reason that it has been proved by an experiment alone."

521. Never say, "Of what use is it to me?" Instead, one should develop the habit of asking, "Of what use could I be?" Then only utilitarianism would make sense.

522. "Who is the Creator of the world?"

"I alone am the creator of my world." I have absolutely no knowledge of any other world.

523. How can eternal truths be revealed to the reason blinded by faith in the objective reality?

524. (i) Introspection

(ii) Silence

(iii) Selfless action without attachment.

(iv) Prayer.

525. Virtues are inherently free and flowing. Virtues which stagnate surely degenerate into vices.

526. It is possible to gain political power through violence, but not *swaraj* (self-rule). *Swaraj* and nonviolence are one and the same.

527. One should follow duties towards one's family, community and nation. What is forbidden is undue pride of family, community and nation.

528. Three kinds of Self: The sinful self, the purified Self and the Supreme Self.

529. There is transgression of the vow of control of the palate in rejecting work that comes one's way and preferring that which one likes.

530. Where spiritual endeavour is concerned, the phrase 'to the best of one's ability' means to reach the point where strength breaks down.

531. (i) Do not give up the essence of your personality,

(ii) Do not give up principles,

(iii) At least, do not transgress the limits of ordinary morality.

532. *Pratyahar* (the withdrawal of senses from their natural outward functioning) is three-fold:

(i) Withdrawal of sense organs for the sake of contemplation,

(ii) Giving the sense organs free play for singing the praise of the Lord,

(iii) Using them with restraint during the normal course of life.

533. Devotion is of four kinds: (i) *Para*—Devotion to the Supreme, (ii) *Eka*—Devotion to only one object of adoration, (iii) *Priya*—Devotion to one who is dear, (iv) *Poojya*—Devotion to one who is revered.

534. *Advaita* (non-dualism), which does not countenance the performance of even the regular ordinary action, is prepared to swallow even the forbidden actions.

535. Vedic words have profoundly subtle meanings. In the course of time, they lent themselves to gross and popular interpretations. It is but the law of nature that the gross should be born from the subtle, the manifest from the unmanifest.

536. Lord Krishna used to consider himself an ordinary milkman and even people used to, and even now, consider Him so. It is in the latter fact that the uniqueness of Lord Krishna's quality of complete absence of vanity lies.

537. Crops that grow above the soil belong to the farmer. But underground treasure is the property of all. Similarly, ordinary ideas belong to the land of their birth, but extraordinary thoughts are the property of the whole world.

538. There are two great forces which are working in the world: (i) The power of Truth and (ii) The power of faith in the Holy Name.

539. That morality and devotion should stay well in the world is the aim of religion.

540. Belief in the authority of the Vedas means sense of gratefulness to the ancient tradition and freedom for inspired and venturesome effort in new directions.

541. Lord Krishna saved the cow. Lord Buddha tried to save the goat.

542. Lord Krishna tells Arjun, "Do as you like" (Gita, 18.63). And then also says, "Surrender to Me alone" (18.66).

It is in the fitness of things that liberty should accept restraint as its companion of its own accord.

543. Non-action in action is a concrete sign of Self-knowledge. Action in non-action is an abstract sign of Self-knowledge.

544. There are four types of sophisticated reasoning:

(i) Hypocritical reasoning,

(ii) Ignorant reasoning,

(iii) Reasoning based on the substance (of a theory).

iv) Reasoning based on objectivity or realism.

545. It is a custom to place a person on the verge of death on a coarse blanket (on the floor). Let there be simplicity at the time of death, if not during life.

546. Imperialism means excessive attachment to wealth, political power and one's civilization.

547. "Know them to be devotees of God who are indifferent to the body." (Tukaram)

Every problem has a body (which is its external aspect) and a soul (which is its inner core). A devotee is naturally indifferent to the external aspect.

548. Universal brotherhood will not be established in the world unless the paternal authority of God is accepted.

549. A saint, like the sun, will ripen grain in fields. A social reformer, like the household fire, will cook rice.

550. Lord Krishna appeared as Love incarnate to the milkmaids (of Gokul), as Compassion incarnate to Draupadi⁵³, as Wisdom incarnate to Arjuna⁵⁴, as forgiveness incarnate to the hunter⁵⁵.

551. Worship is of three kinds:

- (i) Based on introspection—serious and earnest,
- (ii) Based on the vision of God—blissful,
- (iii) Based on philosophical reflection—quiet and peaceful.

552. Going beyond the mind is like spiritual sleep. A state of enlightenment is like spiritual wakefulness. Both the states lend themselves to mutual verification.

553. Power resides in unswerving devotion to Truth. Power belongs to whosoever is so devoted. This itself is known as the *adhishthana*—the benedictory presence—of God in support of any undertaking.

53. The Lord provided garments to Draupadi, who was being disrobed in the Kaurava court.

54. Reference is to the Lord's exposition of the Gita.

55. Lord Krishna's departure from the world was caused by an arrow shot by a hunter who mistook the Lord's feet as a deer. The Lord forgave him too.

554. The seers have revelation, the philosophers have knowledge, the saints have (spiritual) experience.

555. "Do you believe in the theory of *vivarta* as illustrated by the deceptive perception of a serpent in the place of a rope, or in the theory of *parinama* as illustrated by the perception of gold in the golden bangle?"

"I believe in the theory of *vivarta* as illustrated by the example of a golden bangle."⁵⁶

556. One should have faith in the authority of pure reason, not an egoistic belief in one's own judgements.

557. The ant is the best preceptor. The bird is the best disciple.

558. (i) One-pointed non-dualism knows only one way of attaining to spiritual perfection and hence cannot imagine the existence of any other way.

(ii) Sensible non-dualism is committed to only one way of attaining to spiritual perfection, yet acknowledges that there can be other ways.

(iii) Non-dualism which accepts the truth in all the standpoints believes in combining all the means for the purpose.

(iv) Extreme non-dualism does not see any difference between different means in the spiritual endeavour.

56. A rope appears like a serpent in darkness, but it is an illusion. Similarly, it is an illusion that we perceive the phenomenal world in the place of Brahman. This is the theory of *vivarta*. The theory of *parinama* says that Brahman has assumed the form of the phenomenal world, just as gold takes the form of a bangle. Vinoba appears to suggest that Brahman has indeed assumed the form of the phenomenal world, and it is our illusion that we perceive it as something different from Brahman.

559. Life is what is arrived at by multiplication of thoughts, experiences and faith.

560. The saints are as lovingly kind as a cow. That is why they chew and digest roughage of philosophy and produce for the common folk the milk of morality and devotion.

561. Increase in enthusiasm, subduing of passions and enrichment of knowledge are the distinguishing marks of an undisturbed sound sleep.

562. The grain of wheat knows much better than the hand of the sower when to put forth the sprout. A doer of an action should not worry about the resultant fruit. The action itself is capable of looking after it.

563. The Vedas speak because that is their inherent nature. The preceptors speak with a view to imparting instruction. For me, speaking is like repetition of the Name of the Lord.

564. It is no wonder that failures have to be faced often. Success means the end of an undertaking. How can the end come often? It can come only once.

565. Nonviolence does not mean lenient tolerance, nor does it mean intolerable rigorous regulation.

566. Charity is an act of expiation for the sin of accumulation. There is, therefore, no room for pride in it.

567. Non-stealing regulates the mode of accumulation; non-possession regulates the extent of accumulation. Effectively, both are one and the same.

568. Respiration is the best illustration of the application of the principle of non-possession under the Divine scheme of things.

569. *Yajna* consists of five elements: dedication to God, service of living beings, austerities, regulated use of

life's necessities and renunciation.

570. The meritorious is entitled to approach God, because he is meritorious. The sinner is entitled to approach God, because he is a sinner.

571. Once in a dream a tiger started chasing me. I took to my heels. An ascetic also jointed me. In a matter of a few seconds, we arrived at a prayer ground. The tiger was following us. The ascetic all of a sudden sat down at the prayer ground and said to me, "I refuse to run hereafter. You may fend for yourself."

Trembling all over, I too gathered courage to sit near him. And lo! The tiger vanished and the dream also came to an end.

572. The abstract without qualities and the concrete with qualities, the worshipped and the worshipper, I and you, good persons and bad persons, inanimate and animate—when all these differences end, there will be perfect *advaita* (non-duality).

573. Will, endeavour, God's grace, attainment.

574. Action > Non-action.

But (spiritual) knowledge + action = (spiritual) knowledge + non-action,
for (spiritual) knowledge = ∞ (Infinity).

575. There is no experience which can stand comparison with the spiritual experience that Vedanta (Upanishadic philosophy) leads to. There is no science that can compete with mathematics. There is no art which can surpass the culinary art.

576. Attachment to body, attachment to knowledge, attachment to compassion.

577. I do not relish any other way of viewing action except as an agent for purifying the mind.

578. The breeze blows into my room of its own accord. The sun enters my room of its own accord. Similarly, God also is going to visit me of His own accord. It is enough if I keep my room vacant.

579. One should constantly remember God's beauty, power, knowledge, sacredness and love.

580. 'Ambition' —

What an insignificant thing it is!

581. (i) Steadfastness of reason

(ii) Selfless service

(iii) Control of the sense organs

(iv) Tenderness of loving devotion

(v) Self-knowledge

(vi) Development of divine qualities and

(vii) Renunciation.

—These are the seven constituents that make a religion complete.

582. It is in the fresh open air that one meets *Sachchidananda*—the Supreme.⁵⁷

Sky—Truth

Air—Consciousness

Light—Bliss

583. If devotion were to be like the mother and yoga like the father, that would naturally give rise to spiritual knowledge in us children. This also indicates how education should be given to women and men.

584. In a brahmachari, a man and a woman exist together.

585 Reason is not weak like faith. Reason is not strong like faith.

57. Brahman is believed to have three aspects: *Sat* (Truth), *Chit* (Consciousness) and *Ananda* (Bliss).

586. To look too far ahead and not to look at all are the two effective ways for stumbling and getting hurt.

587. Vision is more valuable than knowledge.

588. Freedom from fear has two aspects: I should not be afraid of anyone and no one should be afraid of me. I find this in sky. 'I must reduce myself to zero like sky' is the obvious implication of this.

589. To say that a particular person has a higher or lower position is as senseless as saying that a particular star is at a higher level or lower level. What one should say is that both are located at different positions in the same sky.

590. That nature of things appears to change constantly does not mean that the thing is illusory; it is the indication of its grandeur.

591. When passion vanishes, the world around becomes both valueless and invaluable.

592. Five constituents are basic to all religions:

(i) *Shruti* (fundamental principles),

(ii) *Smriti* (social traditions),

(iii) Mythology (lives of saints in the past),

(iv) Devotion (worship),

(v) Ethics (proven values like truth and nonviolence).

593. Service—to an individual.

Devotion—to the whole community.

594. A human being is like a house

His good qualities are like doors of that house.

His failings and drawbacks are like its walls.

